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Porter Ranch residents and activists rally to shut down Aliso Canyon gas field

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Residents, activists and elected officials rallied in Porter Ranch on Tuesday, Aug. 22, demanding that California Gov. Gavin Newsom phase out the Aliso Canyon underground natural gas storage facility located in the Santa Susana Mountains between the Simi and San Fernando valleys.

Dozens of San Fernando Valley residents gathered at the corner of Rinaldi Street and Tampa Avenue near the entrance to the facility, which in 2015 became the site of the biggest methane release in U.S. history. The leak went on for more than 100 days, spewing 100,000 metric tons of methane into the air and forcing thousands of people to evacuate from their homes.

The Tuesday rally came on the heels of a proposal by state regulators to expand the capacity of Aliso Canyon. The California Public Utilities Commission (CPUC) will vote on Aug. 31 on whether to approve increasing the underground gas storage facility.

Lori Aivazian, a member of the Aliso Moms Alliance, worries about the safety of children who live and attend schools near the Aliso Canyon facility.

"We urge the CPUC to stand by its framework to shut down the Aliso Canyon Storage Facility by 2027, which is supported by former Governor Brown, Governor Newsom, and numerous California state, and Los Angeles county and city officials," she said.

Helen Attai, a resident of Granada Hills, called the Aliso Canyon site dangerous and said she was planning to call state commissioners next week, asking them to vote against expanding the field.

"It has to be shut down," she said. "It's making all of us sick."

In the years after the 2015 disaster, many residents and activists rallied to shut down the facility, but its owner, SoCalGas, went on to increase its storage limits, arguing that the expansion was necessary for energy reliability.

In 2020, California state regulators allowed the gas company to increase Aliso Canyon's storage limits to 34 billion cubic feet, and a year later its capacity was increased to 41 billion cubic feet — despite promises from Newsom to phase out the facility by 2027.

On Tuesday, rally-goers urged Gov. Newsom and state regulators to streamline the shutting down of Aliso Canyon — instead of expanding it once again. Some held signs that read, "Gov. Newsom, Shut Aliso Down" and "Keep Your Promise, Shut Aliso Canyon Down."

State Sen. Henry Stern said he was optimistic ahead of the next week's meeting and hoped that if state regulators vote to expand the facility they would offer a path for its closure.

"We don't think it should be filled up again," Stern said. "We don't think we need it, but if you do it, you should be finalizing the Aliso Canyon closure pathway at the same time. So that this community trusts you."

Chris Gilbride, a SoCalGas spokesperson, wrote in an email, "The CPUC's proposal to increase local natural gas storage levels ahead of winter is a prudent step that would help advance our shared goal of maintaining energy reliability at just and reasonable rates."

State energy officials recommended in July an increase in the amount of natural gas that SoCalGas can inject down into the Aliso Canyon underground facility, boosting the gas being stored there to help avert possible shortages during future winters.

The CPUC administrators have proposed expanding the storage volume from 41 billion cubic feet to 68.6 billion cubic feet, or about 65% more volume.

The state administrators said the increase was necessary "to modify the maximum storage level to protect natural gas and electricity customers from reliability and economic impacts during winter 2023-2024," according to a proposal filed in late July.

A letter signed by more than 50 environmental groups said the Aliso Canyon facility poses "significant danger" to the health and safety of residents who live near the underground storage field, urging state officials to reject any attempts by the gas company to boost storage limits — and instead expedite its closure.

According to the letter, during the two years following the 2015 leak, "Aliso Canyon was under strict regulations and withdrawals were not permitted unless in the case of an emergency. During that time, the Southern California region did not face blackouts or gas supply shortages as a result of Aliso Canyon being offline."

California state Sen. Stern, Congressman Brad Sherman and state Assemblymember Pilar Schiavo wrote in a joint statement earlier this month that "the impacted communities deserve reassurance this will not undercut the governor's commitment to closure and the increase is, in fact, necessary. Such assurance is possible, alongside this decision, if the CPUC finalized their long delayed, but well-proposed decision to phase out Aliso responsibly. This proposal goes in the opposite direction."

In a letter submitted to the CPUC on Aug. 22, Stern and other elected officials including Schiavo and state legislators Jesse Gabriel and Ben Allen, said they were "extremely disappointed and frustrated over the Administrative Law Judge's July 26, 2023, Proposed Decision, recommending that the Aliso Canyon Natural Gas Storage Facility be allowed to return to maximum capacity. Not only is this unacceptable to the communities in and around Aliso Canyon, who to this day, are still exposed to harmful chemical constituents from the continued operation of the facility."

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